

Day 3 — The Six Vedangas

Module: What is IKS? (Middle) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students name the six Vedāṅgas (auxiliary disciplines) and match each to its function in preserving and applying Vedic knowledge.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Matching-game cards (6 names + 6 functions, shuffled)

Vocabulary

- *Vedāṅga* — “limb of the Veda”
- *vyākaraṇa* — “grammar; analysis”
- *jyotiṣa* — “luminary; astronomy/astrology”

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Daily prompt + recall: 2 students name the 4 Vedas + 4 layers from yesterday.

Core (20 min)

1. **The Six Vedāṅgas** (write on board, then build each row):

#	Sanskrit	Function	Modern equivalent
1	<i>Śikṣā</i>	Phonetics, pronunciation	Linguistics / phonology
2	<i>Kalpa</i>	Ritual procedure	Liturgy
3	<i>Vyākaraṇa</i>	Grammar (peaks in Pāṇini ~4th c. BCE)	Formal grammar / parsing
4	<i>Nirukta</i>	Etymology	Lexicography
5	<i>Chandas</i>	Prosody (poetic metre)	Poetics
6	<i>Jyotiṣa</i>	Astronomy / time-keeping	Astronomy + astrology

2. **Why they exist.** The Vedas had to be transmitted PRECISELY, orally, across millennia. Six disciplines grew up around the texts to ensure correct pronunciation, ritual use, grammatical understanding, etymological clarity, metrical recitation, and astronomical timing.

3. One stand-out: Pāṇini's *Aṣṭādhyāyī* (~4th c. BCE).

- ~4000 sūtras describing Sanskrit grammar.
- Considered the first known formal grammar of any language.
- Influenced modern formal-language theory (Chomsky's generative grammar acknowledges Pāṇinian inspiration).
- A single Vedāṅga (vyākaraṇa) produced one of the most important works in the history of linguistics.

4. One more stand-out: Jyotiṣa.

- The astronomy/astrology pair. Distinguish: jyotiṣa contains BOTH calculation (astronomy) and interpretation (astrology). Modern science separates these; the Indian tradition kept them together.

Activity (15 min) — Matching game

Pairs. 12 cards (6 Sanskrit names + 6 function descriptions) shuffled face-down. Memory-match game. First pair done writes their match on the board.

Then class discusses: “Which Vedāṅga surprised you most? Why?”

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Exit ticket: name 3 of the 6 Vedāṅgas with their functions.
- Preview Day 4: “Tomorrow — the Upavedas. Four APPLIED sciences.”

Student-facing content

The Six Vedāṅgas — “limbs of the Veda”

#	Sanskrit	Function
1	Śikṣā	Pronunciation, phonetics
2	Kalpa	Ritual procedure
3	Vyākaraṇa	Grammar
4	Nirukta	Etymology
5	Chandas	Poetic metre
6	Jyotiṣa	Astronomy & astrology

Pāṇini's *Aṣṭādhyāyī* (~4th c. BCE) — under Vyākaraṇa — is widely considered the first formal grammar of any language. ~4000 sūtras.

Homework

- Look up ONE Sanskrit word in an online etymology resource. Note where it might appear in English vocabulary (e.g. *mātr* → mother). Bring tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read about the Chomsky-Pāṇini connection — find 1 specific example of Pāṇinian influence on modern linguistics.

- **Tier down:** Memorise just 3 Vedāṅgas: Vyākaraṇa, Jyotiṣa, Kalpa.

Teacher notes

- Students often confuse Jyotiṣa with horoscope-astrology. Distinguish: the discipline contained BOTH planetary calculation AND interpretive use. Modern science separates these.
- The “first formal grammar” claim about Pāṇini is mainstream scholarly view (Cardona, Kiparsky, etc.). Defensible.

Citation(s) used

- Pollock (2006) on Vedic disciplines.
- Cardona, G. (1997). *Pāṇini: His Work and Its Traditions*. Motilal Banarsidass.